

Borne on the wind



Dandelion fruits floating away on the breeze

ACCORDING TO TRADITION, if you blow on a dandelion's seed head, the number of puffs needed to blow away all the seeds will tell you the time of day. Whether or not this is true, it is a custom that certainly helps the plant to spread. The seeds of the dandelion are encased in tiny fruits and have their own special feathery parachutes to help them float through the air. If you blow on them, you may be starting the seeds on a journey that takes them high up and far away. The dandelion's flower,

like that of the sunflower (p. 21), is actually a composite flower head made up of many tiny florets. Each of the florets produces a single fruit. Like the dandelion, many other composite plants, such as hawkweeds, ragworts, and thistles, rely on the wind to disperse their seeds. The fruits of some of these have parachutes; others have fine hairs that stick out in all directions to form a feathery ball.

Many of these plants are troublesome weeds because they quickly colonize bare soil in gardens and on farmland.

1 OPENING TIME

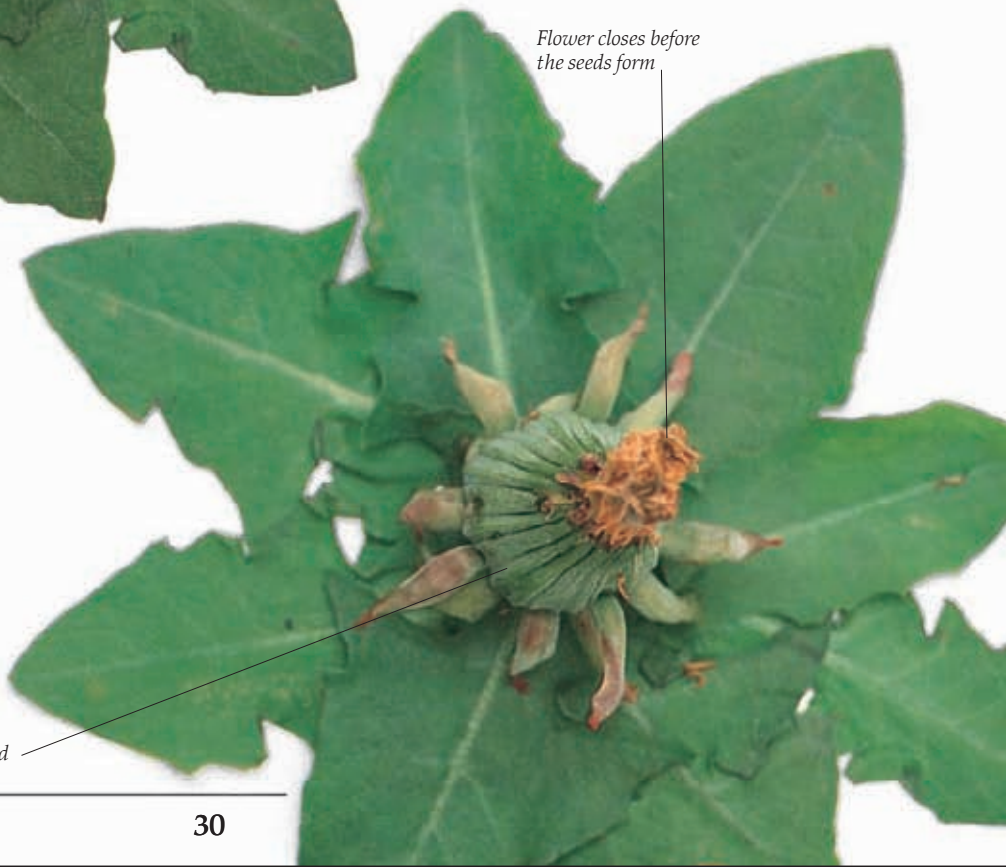
The dandelion's flower opens in the morning and closes in the afternoon or when it rains. The plant's name comes from the French *dent de lion*, meaning lion's tooth, which describes the jagged edges of the leaves.



Flower head open, waiting to be pollinated by a passing insect

2 THE SEEDS START TO FORM

After opening and closing for a number of days, during which time it may be pollinated, the flower finally closes, and seed formation begins. Gradually, the yellow petals wither away, and the pappus, which is the name given to the small circle of hairs attached to the top of each fruit, starts to grow longer. This is the beginning of the parachute.



Flower closes before the seeds form

Bracts protect the developing seed head